



RELOCATION GUIDE · NEW ZEALAND

Wellington

Tē Whanganui-a-Tara

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Wellington.

Ethicare Resourcing

September 2026 · ethicareresourcing.com

Nau mai ki Te Whanganui-a-Tara

Welcome to Wellington

Moving country is a bold thing to do, and it is rarely only about the job. This guide is here to make the practical parts easier: where people live, what the work is like, how you would get around, and what an ordinary week might actually feel like.

It is written by people who arrange these moves for a living, which means two things. We know the questions that arrive at two in the morning. And we would rather tell you the awkward parts now than have you find them in month three.

Nothing in here is a pitch. If Wellington turns out to be the wrong answer for you, this guide should help you work that out just as quickly – and that is a good outcome, not a failed one.

Whatever you decide, you are welcome to ask us anything at all.

Sophie

FOUNDER, ETHICARE RESOURCING

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This is the short version. Every section here has a fuller chapter on our website, kept up to date — so if something looks time-sensitive, check there. We have left rents, salaries and other figures out on purpose: a number that was right when this was written would be quietly wrong by the time you read it, and a PDF cannot be corrected once it is sent. Those live on the site instead.



01

NAU MAI, HAERE MAI

Welcome to Wellington

Nau mai, haere mai ki Te Whanganui-a-Tara. If you're reading this you're somewhere between curious and committed. Either is a good place to be, and this guide is written for both.

8 KM

Across at its widest. The whole city, hills to harbour.

~215,000

People in the city, around 440,000 across the wider region.

15 MIN

A typical commute. The single biggest lifestyle variable between NZ cities.

A city small enough to belong to quickly

Wellington is the smallest capital most people have lived in, and that's the whole character of the place. It has a tertiary hospital, a parliament, a national museum, a theatre scene and a working port — all inside a city you can walk across in an afternoon.

The effect on a newcomer is unusual. You'll run into the same people. Your registrar will know your neighbour. Within two months you'll have a coffee place where they start your order when you walk in. In a bigger city that takes years, and for a lot of people moving countries alone, it's the thing that makes the move survivable.

The city, in nine numbers

Not a fact sheet. These are the nine figures that actually shape a week here.

Six things you only learn by living here

Small, specific, and the sort of thing that makes the first month feel less foreign if you know it in advance.



02 THE CASE FOR THE CAPITAL

Why Wellington

The case for the capital comes down to one number: twenty minutes. What you do with the hours that buys you is the actual argument.

MONDAY

Walk to work along the waterfront. Home by six, and the evening is still an evening.

TUESDAY

Late finish, but the drive home is fifteen minutes and there's no motorway in it.

WEDNESDAY

Football or a hill run straight from the office. The trailhead is inside the city.

Small is the feature, not the compromise

Wellington is hemmed in by hills on one side and the harbour on the other, which means it never sprawled. The city that resulted is roughly eight kilometres across at its widest, with a tertiary hospital, a university campus, the seat of government, a theatre district and a working port all inside that.

The consequence for you is arithmetic. A thirty-five-minute commute each way, five days a week, is roughly six hours. Fifteen minutes each way is two and a half. That difference – most of a working day, every week – is the single largest lifestyle variable between New Zealand cities, and it compounds over years.

What twenty minutes actually buys

One clinician's week, in the shape it tends to take here. Not a promise – an illustration of what becomes possible when the commute stops eating the evening.

The six things people ask us

For most specialties, yes. Wellington Regional is a tertiary centre serving the lower North Island and the top of the South, and it holds several national and supra-regional services. Auckland has more volume; Wellington has a catchment that pulls complex work to a compact, well-connected campus.

It is the most exaggerated and the most real thing about Wellington at the same time. There are perhaps twenty days a year when it is unpleasant, a lot of days when it is simply present, and stretches in autumn that are among the most beautiful weather in the country. Most people acclimatise within a year; a small number never do.

What we'd ask you to weigh

Every one of these is a real reason people leave. Read them properly – it's cheaper to decide against Wellington now than in eighteen months.

Weighing Wellington against Auckland or somewhere smaller is a sensible thing to do properly. Our [New Zealand destination guides](#) cover each region just as honestly.



03 THE SHAPE OF IT

Wellington at a glance

A harbour in a drowned river valley, ringed by hills, sitting on a plate boundary at the windiest point in the country. The geography explains almost everything about this city.

Everything here is explained by the hills and the strait

Wellington sits at the southern tip of the North Island, on a harbour formed when a river valley flooded. Steep hills rise directly from the water on three sides, and Cook Strait — a forty-kilometre gap between two mountainous islands — opens to the south.

That single arrangement produces the compact walkable centre, the houses stacked up hillsides with a hundred steps to the door, the absence of motorways through town, the four rail lines threading up the only flat corridors, and the wind. Understand the geography and the rest of this guide reads as consequence.

"Wellington" means four quite different places

People say Wellington and mean the city. The region is larger, and which part you live in changes your rent, your commute and your weekends considerably.

Same salary in all four. What changes is your rent, your commute and what you do on a Saturday — which is the whole decision, compressed into one chart.

Mild, changeable, and windier than anywhere you've lived

The temperature range here is narrow. Winters rarely freeze and summers rarely get properly hot — a mean around thirteen degrees, and a good summer day in the low twenties. If you're coming from northern Europe the winters will feel mild; from the Middle East or India, the summers will feel cool.

The wind is the real story. Cook Strait funnels air between two mountain ranges, and Wellington sits in the gap.

The fault line, plainly

Wellington sits on a plate boundary and everyone knows it. You'll feel small earthquakes; most people stop noticing within a year.

Whose place this is

Te Whanganui-a-Tara — the great harbour of Tara. Taranaki Whānui and Ngāti Toa Rangatira are the mana whenua of the region, and both are visible in the city's institutions, place names and the way the health service works.

You'll hear te reo daily, in meetings and on signage. What that means at work — pronunciation, the words you'll hear on the ward, Te Tiriti and marae etiquette — is national, and covered in [Te ao Māori at work](#).

Healthcare in Wellington

A tertiary hospital serving the lower half of the North Island, ten minutes from the harbour — and the national health bodies down the road.

NEWTOWN

The largest private hospital in the region sits close to the regional hospital, which makes cross-sector work about as convenient as it gets anywhere in the country.

CROFTON DOWNS

Surgical and medical private care on the north-western side of the city, close to Karori, Khandallah and the Johnsonville line suburbs.

ACROSS THE REGION

Day-stay, endoscopy and imaging facilities, alongside community radiology networks with clinics through the city, the Hutt Valley and Porirua.

A small city doing tertiary work for a large region

This is the thing that surprises clinicians most about Wellington. The city is modest — around 215,000 people, 440,000 across the region — but the region's tertiary hospital serves the lower North Island and parts of the upper South Island, a catchment of roughly nine hundred thousand.

The practical effect is a case mix considerably more complex than the population suggests, delivered by teams considerably smaller than you'd find in Auckland. You get subspecialty exposure with the intimacy of a district hospital, which is either the ideal combination or an uncomfortable stretch depending on how you like to work.

The four public hospitals

Four public hospitals serve the greater Wellington region. Which one you join shapes your commute, your caseload and how far you live from the city.

They sit along one line of geography — up the western corridor, through the city, out along the valley and over the hill. Where you join decides which end of it you live at.

A private sector that's easier to move within

Wellington's private sector is compact — a handful of hospitals doing planned surgery, endoscopy, diagnostics and day procedures, funded by insurance, by ACC, by patients directly and increasingly by Health New Zealand outsourcing elective lists.

Because everything is close together, working across both sectors is unusually practical. A public list in Newtown in the morning and a private list nearby in the afternoon is a short drive, not a cross-town expedition.

Beyond the wards

Hospitals are the obvious employer. Three more account for a great deal of the clinical work in the region.

What's different here

Almost everything clinicians tell us about working in Wellington traces back to one fact: the teams are small. That is the appeal and the cost, and it is worth reading both columns before you decide.

What ACC covers, how enrolment works and what everyday care costs are national — see [How the health system works](#).



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FOURTEEN SUBURBS

Where clinicians live

Fourteen suburbs, sorted by commute to whichever hospital you'll work at. In Wellington the variables are unusual: sun, wind exposure and how many steps to your front door.

ONE · WHICH HOSPITAL?

Everything follows from this. Newtown for the regional hospital, the valley for Hutt, the northern suburbs for Kenepuru, over the hill for Wairarapa. Wellington is small but the harbour and the hills make some journeys much longer than the map suggests.

TWO · CAR, TRAIN, OR ON FOOT?

If you want to be car-free you need an inner suburb or a rail line — those are genuinely different sets of suburbs. If you're driving, off-street parking becomes the thing you fight for, and many older houses simply don't have it.

THREE · SUN OR SPACE?

The Wellington trade nobody warns you about. North-facing, sunny and sheltered costs a premium and the houses are smaller. South-facing or wind-exposed gets you more room for less money, and a much colder winter.



Character homes on the hill — and the steps that come with them

Three questions, in this order

Settle these before you look at a single listing. In a city this small, getting the order right saves you from a lease you regret.

Pick your hospital, then read down

Suburbs reorder by commute to whichever hospital you select. Rents are indicative weekly figures for a three-bedroom house as at July 2026 — treat them as a shape, not a quote.

Commutes are typical door-to-door driving times outside peak, and Wellington peak adds meaningfully to the longer ones. Rents move — check current listings before budgeting.

The three things that decide a Wellington house

Anywhere else you look at bedrooms, schools and the commute. Here those matter too, but three local variables will affect your daily life more, and none of them appear on a listing in any useful form. Locals assess a house on these before they look at the kitchen. It takes newcomers about one winter to understand why.

How renting works nationally – applications, bond, tenancy rights and the Healthy Homes standards – is the same everywhere, and set out in [Renting in New Zealand](#).



06 WHAT LIFE COSTS

Cost of living

*Same salary as Auckland, meaningfully lower rent —
and one bill that will surprise you in July.*

Why there are no prices on this page

What does not go stale is the *shape* of a month, and the judgement about which lines will surprise you — which is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare Wellington against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

Because clinical pay sits on national collective agreements, your gross salary here is identical to Auckland's. Housing costs less. That gap is the quiet financial case for Wellington, and it doesn't appear on any job advertisement.

What a month costs

Indicative New Zealand dollars per month as at July 2026, for a household living moderately. Your own numbers will differ — treat this as a shape to sanity-check against, not a quote.

Rent is over half of it. Everything else put together is smaller than the roof over your head — which is exactly why the Wellington rent gap matters more than any other line here.

The one bill that catches everyone out

Your power bill in July can be two or three times what it was in February. This isn't a New Zealand pricing quirk — it's what happens when a poorly insulated timber house meets a cold, damp winter and a heat pump running most of the day.

People arriving in summer sign a lease based on a February bill, then get a July one and think something has gone wrong. Nothing has. Budget for the winter figure from the start and treat the summer months as the discount.

Setting up costs

Unfurnished here can mean genuinely empty — no fridge, no washing machine, sometimes no curtains. Budget for the first fortnight properly.

Bars are to scale against each other, so you can see where the money actually goes before you've bought a kettle.

Cheaper than Auckland, and where it shows

These are live and updated continuously, which is why we send you to them rather than competing with them. Put the city you are leaving in the other box.

If what you find contradicts the judgement on this page, tell us. We would rather correct the page than defend it.



07

SIX WAYS AROUND

Getting around

The only New Zealand city where "do I need a car?" has a interesting answer. Four rail lines, a cable car, a harbour ferry, and a walkable centre.

Probably not for work. Probably yes for weekends.

This is the honest answer and it holds for most clinicians here. If you live in an inner suburb or on a rail line, getting to work without a car is straightforward and often faster than driving. Plenty of Wellington staff genuinely don't own one.

But the things people move to Wellington for — the south coast in a swell, a trailhead in the Remutakas, Martinborough on a Saturday, the ferry terminal at seven in the morning — mostly need a vehicle. Many households here run one car between two adults rather than none or two.

Six ways around a small city

Wellington has more genuine transport options than anywhere else in the country, mostly because the geography left no room to build motorways through it.

The four rail lines

If you're choosing a suburb for a car-free life, this is the map that matters.

Indicative — each line has more stops than shown. Check Metlink for the full timetable, and check it against your roster rather than the advertised peak frequency.

Leaving the city

Travel time from the city, to scale against each other. The airport is the outlier that makes Wellington feel small; the road north is the one that reminds you the country is long.



08

COFFEE STARTED HERE

Food, coffee & the everyday

New Zealand's coffee culture started here and the city has never got over it. More cafés and bars per head than New York, in a place you can walk across.

CUBA STREET

The heart of it. Independent, scruffy, excellent — bars, cheap eats, live music and the best people-watching in the country. Go for a long evening that starts without a plan.

COURTENAY PLACE

Louder and later. Theatres at one end, bars along the length, and where the city goes after a show. Go for a Friday.

THE WATERFRONT & QUEENS WHARF

Harbour-edge dining and the walk home along the water. Go for a summer evening or when family visit.

The city that taught New Zealand to drink coffee

In the late 1980s a handful of Wellington roasters started taking espresso seriously, and the habit spread outward from here to the rest of the country. The roastery names are local institutions, and most cafés will tell you whose beans they pull without being asked.

The practical consequence for you is that mediocre coffee is genuinely hard to find, and that your morning flat white becomes a small daily pleasure rather than a transaction. It also means Wellingtonians are insufferable about it, and you'll become one within about four months.

The vocabulary, so your first order goes smoothly

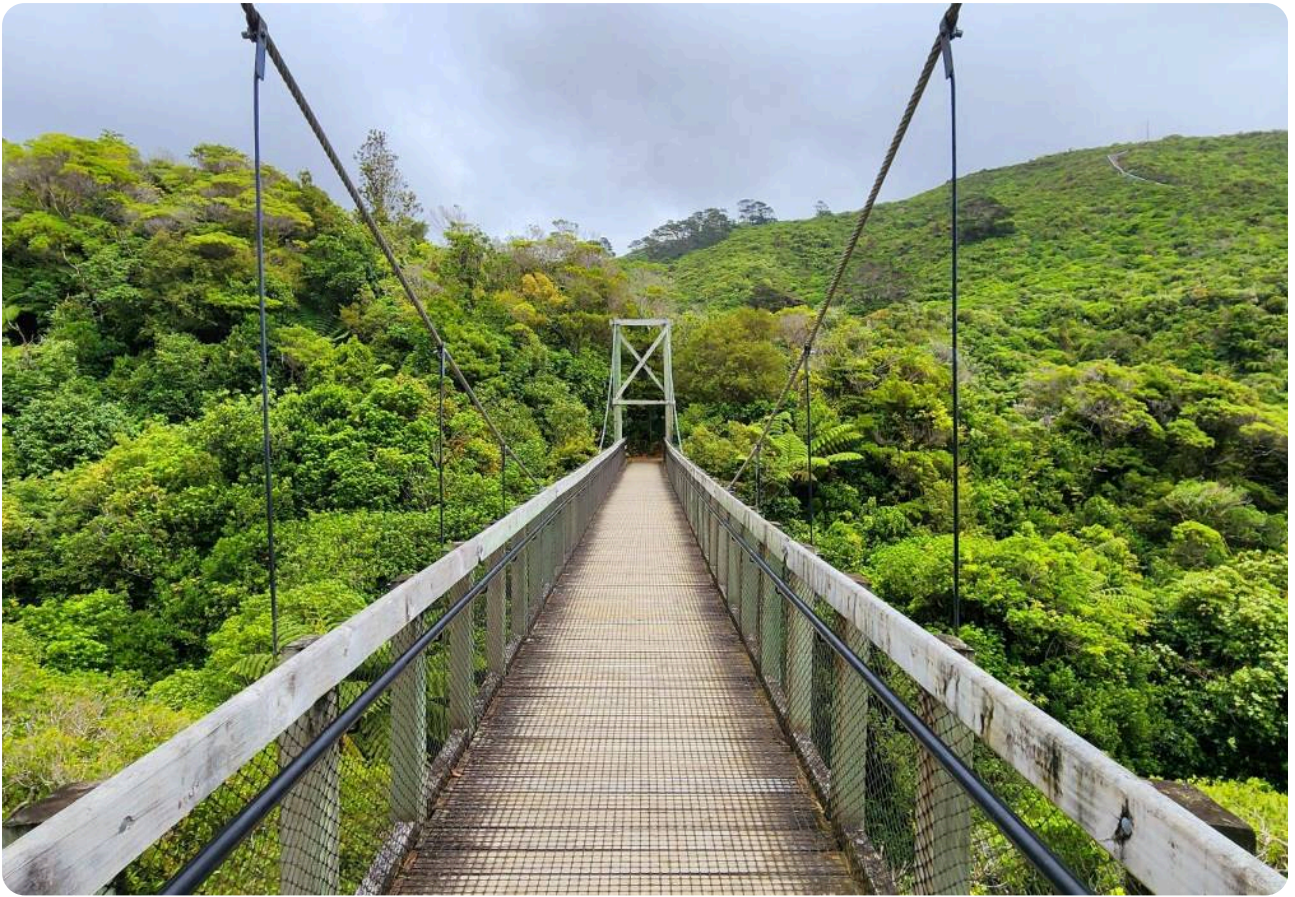
Not a joke section. The words genuinely differ from the UK, the US and the Gulf, and getting them right on day one saves a small daily awkwardness.

Six parts of the city, six different evenings

Districts rather than individual restaurants — places change, and Sophie's own list is coming. This is what each part of town is for.

Wine country, an hour away

Over the Remutaka Hill sits the Wairarapa, and at its centre Martinborough — a village surrounded by vineyards, small enough to cycle between them in an afternoon.



09

WHAT THE COMMUTE BUYS

Harbour, hills & the outdoors

Bush tracks fifteen minutes from most front doors, a wild coast facing Antarctica, and a predator-free valley in the middle of the city. This is what the short commute is for.

KĀKĀ

Large olive-brown parrots with a flash of red under the wing. Raucous at dawn and dusk, and increasingly common in the suburbs.

TŪĪ

Iridescent black with a white throat tuft. An extraordinary range of clicks, chimes and whistles — some of it beyond human hearing.

KERERŪ

A wood pigeon the size of a small cat. You'll hear the wingbeats before you see it, and it will eventually fall out of a tree.

A capital city where you get woken by a parrot

Zealandia is a fenced, predator-free sanctuary in a valley in the middle of Wellington — 225 hectares of regenerating forest where rats, stoats and possums have been eradicated. Native birds were reintroduced, and then they did something nobody fully planned for: they spread out into the city.

Kākā — large, loud, intelligent forest parrots — now nest in suburban trees and shout from rooftops at dawn. Tūī and kererū are everywhere. Suburbs run their own trapping groups, and it's entirely normal for a neighbour to ask whether you want a rat trap for your garden.

Two coasts, and one of them is dangerous

Wellington has a sheltered harbour side and an exposed southern side, and the difference matters for your safety rather than just your comfort. The harbour is calm, warmer and where families swim. The south coast faces Cook Strait, with strong currents, cold water and surf that arrives fast.

New Zealand's drowning rate is high for a developed country, and a disproportionate share involves people newly arrived who underestimated the water. This isn't a scare paragraph — it's the single most useful safety thing in this guide.

When it's horizontal

Some weekends the weather simply wins. Wellington is unusually good at this, because a small city with a capital's institutions means a lot of indoors worth going to.

Where to go next

You do not need a moving date, a decision or a CV to talk to us. If Wellington is on your list, tell us what you do and what you are weighing up, and we will be straight with you about whether we can help.

Everything on our website is free to read whether or not you ever work with us.

The full Wellington guide – ethicareresourcing.com/destinations/wellington-new-zealand

Registration pathway checker – ethicareresourcing.com/pathway-checker

What reaches your bank account – ethicareresourcing.com/take-home-pay

What the move itself costs – ethicareresourcing.com/cost-calculator

Talk to us – hello@ethicareresourcing.com
